SAFETY

Heart warning signs: when to seek urgent help

Edited 14 October 2026

Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

What are the warning signs?

A heart attack may cause pressure, squeezing, fullness, or pain in the chest. Discomfort may also affect the arms, back, neck, jaw, or stomach. Breathlessness, cold sweat, nausea, or lightheadedness may occur. Symptoms vary. If you suspect a heart attack, seek emergency help immediately, even if you are unsure. [1,3] In the Philippines, call 911. Do not wait for a reply from this unit. [5]

Do not wait for the portal

This website is not an emergency service. Email, a routine phone inquiry, or a rehabilitation appointment should not be your first response to suspected heart attack symptoms. Contact emergency services and follow the dispatcher’s instructions. Do not drive yourself when you may be having a heart attack. Rapid assessment matters because trained emergency staff can begin care and arrange transport. [1,4]

Know the difference from cardiac arrest

A heart attack involves blocked blood flow to part of the heart. Cardiac arrest happens when the heart suddenly stops pumping effectively. A person may collapse, become unresponsive, and stop breathing normally. These are emergencies. If someone is unresponsive and not breathing normally, contact emergency services and follow instructions for CPR and using an available automated external defibrillator. Formal training can help you prepare. [2]

Do not diagnose symptoms yourself

Chest discomfort can have several causes, but deciding it is indigestion or anxiety without assessment can delay treatment. Do not use an online checklist to prove that a heart attack is impossible. Symptoms may differ from an earlier event or from someone else’s experience. Tell emergency staff what happened, when it began, and any known heart history. Avoid waiting for every possible symptom to appear. [1]

Prepare before a crisis

Ask your doctor to explain your personal emergency plan while you are well. Confirm the local emergency contact route, where you can receive urgent care, and what your household should do. Keep your medicine list, allergies, and key medical information accessible. Preparation should make action easier, but collecting documents must never delay calling for help when serious symptoms occur.

Follow prescribed instructions

If you have a medicine prescribed for chest symptoms, ask exactly how to use it and when emergency help is still required. Do not borrow another person’s medicine. Do not delay contacting emergency services while trying several home remedies. Follow the advice of the dispatcher or your treating clinician about immediate treatment. A personal prescription does not replace emergency assessment when symptoms suggest a serious problem.

Discuss the plan with family

Make sure a trusted person knows where your emergency instructions are kept. Discuss the plan calmly, without asking anyone to diagnose you. If you live alone, ask your team how to prepare for a sudden illness. During rehabilitation, tell staff immediately if concerning symptoms begin. Stopping and getting help is more important than finishing an activity, keeping an appointment, or avoiding inconvenience to others.

Practice finding the information

Keep emergency instructions and your medicine list readable and current. Make sure someone you trust can find them. This preparation should help you act quickly and must never delay calling for emergency help.

References

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4. National Health Service. (n.d.). Heart attack. https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/heart-attack/

5. Department of the Interior and Local Government. (2026, September 25). Dilg: Unified 911 hits 96.15% efficiency, handles 12.7 million calls. Philippine Information Agency. https://pia.gov.ph/press-release/dilg-unified-911-hits-96-15-efficiency-handles-12-7-million-calls/

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